The Myth of Closure And the Weight We Choose to Carry

Stuti Shukla/BA(J&MC) III

It is fascinating how wrapped up in the finality of things we can be. We want the books we read to tie up every loose end, movies not to leave a single question unanswered, and even for our own life to end in a neat and tidy, fulfilling manner. So when we're left with some amount of pain or merely a sense of incompleteness, instead of working through our problems, we cry out for the magical remedy that is 'closure'.

Closure is an extremely tempting infliction. It states that as long as we hold on to the explanation, the apology or the missing piece, we will never feel the weight. Closure is a quite handy tool to compartmentalise sorrow into a crevice of the past; allowing us to conveniently move on with our lives, without addressing the simmering lava of feelings bubbling away under the surface.

Closure is an unfinished painting

The problem is, 'closure' doesn't actually exist, it's an illusion. Closure is tethered to pain and those shackles are what we really try to escape.The expectation of closure comes with the captivity of control. We have the inexplicable need for the 'whys' and the 'why nots' in our lives to be answered. Life in its essence, is clarity. We just don't let it come to us and instead go chasing after it, getting lost in the vines of questions that don't matter.

Lovers depart, leaving no explanation for their actions. Parents who despite their love, and in spite of the longing, never utter the reassuring words their children thirst for. Decades old friendships fade away on a whim. To put it simply, grief is chaotic, boundless and defies reason.

The paradox is that there is control in how time does not heal. It simply shows how long one has held onto the pain. As grief researcher Dr. Pauline Boss explains, "Ambiguous loss is the most stressful kind of loss. It defies resolution and creates a state of frozen grief."

Where does closure reside?

The reality we must come to accept is that closure is not given. It does not arrive in perfect conversations nor overdue apologies. The thing about apologies is that they do not erase the feeling of betrayal, and somehow the loss is explained, but it doesn't make it easier.

What closure actually looks like is less sizable, more subdued, and more isolated than we anticipate. It's when we remember that we haven't looked the day we realise the debate has stopped playing repeatedly in our heads. It's the serene change when we no longer require the ones who wounded us, to affirm the healing. Here is where the profound truth resides. We cannot decide what hurts, but we can choose what to hold onto. A lot of people cling to suffering long after the traumatic ordeal has occurred. We may bear guilt for matters beyond our control, hold onto anger as it gives more stability than sadness. We may hold onto resentment, believing it protects, even as it ties us back to history. We may hold onto questions, believing that the correct answer will ultimately provide peace. Some inquiries remain unanswered, certain conclusions stay disordered. By postponing our release until everything is tidy, we gamble on shouldering those burdens indefinitely.

Grappling with the demons of the past in a futile battle, when we could just walk onwards into a brighter future. It's a human fixation, proven by the facts. A 2015 study in The Journal of Positive Psychology found that people who fixated on unresolved events reported significantly higher distress than those who practiced acceptance.

Do not seek, and closure will find you

Releasing without closure starts with recognizing that life doesn't always finish its cycles. Recovery isn't based on everything being logical. It starts when we allow ourselves to recognize our own experiences without requiring anyone else to affirm them. It intensifies as we let go of the hope for apologies that might never arrive. It becomes more powerful when we choose to believe that not every instance of pain should have a lasting role in the narrative. As psychologist Robert Neimeyer notes, "Meaning-making, not closure, is the heart of healing. We don't close the book on grief. We write new chapters."

It becomes life-changing when we establish our own closure, pen the unwritten letter, voice the unuttered farewell, or just acknowledge privately that the conclusion we desired will never come.

Choosing to let go of what has burdened brings strength. Progressing does not equate to erasing. This does not imply that the pain was insignificant. It signifies prioritizing our own well-being over the pain. It signifies not relying on others to give their approval to heal.

Ultimately, closure is not discovered, it isa metamorphosis. The old skin that craves the approval of apologies is shed in favour of one that learns to live with its scars of unanswered questions and unsaid words. A simple recognition of one's self-worth, is enough of a sign that closure is aroud the corner.

Eventually and unknowingly reader, you will noticethat the burden seems less heavy. Bit by bit, it will release its hold. And one day, as you walk down ldroads leading to new hope, you will feel it no more.

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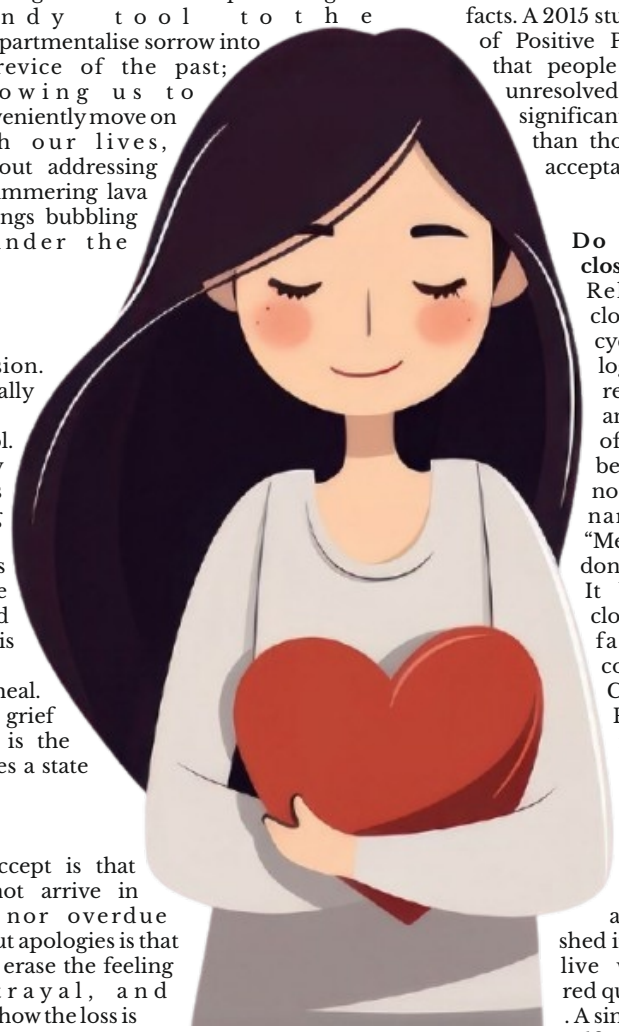

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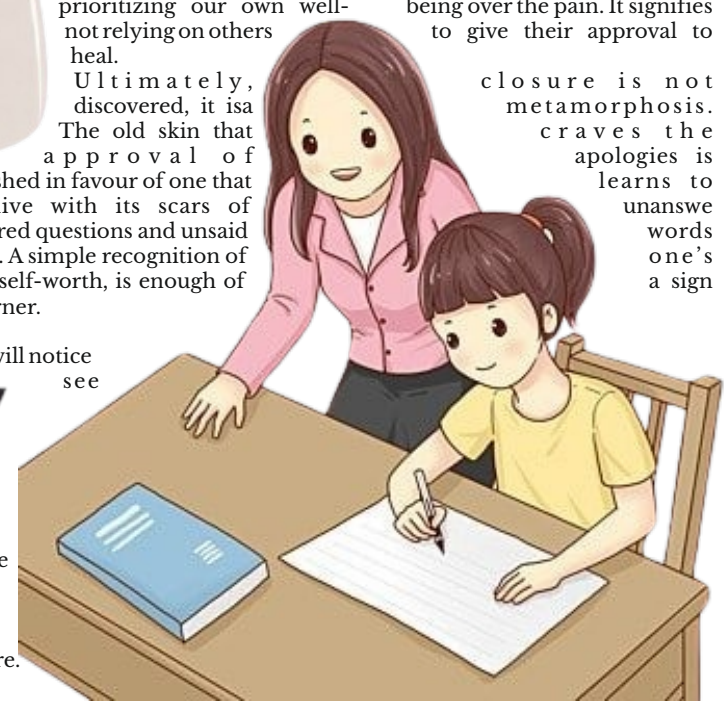
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